

Known for his stance against FDI in higher education, Singh has made nine official foreign trips and has spent over two-and-a-half months in several countries.

Arjun Singh, minister for human resource development ►

During his 670 days in the ministry, Kumar has spent 75 days in countries like Kazakhstan, Egypt, France, Morocco, Italy, Japan, the UK and Canada.

Ashwani Kumar, MoS for commerce and industry

tours. The same may be collected from there directly." Similarly, the Ministry of Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises provided all information except for expenses on the basis that "expenditure on the cabinet minister's tour is booked under head 'Council of Minister Tour Expenses maintained by Cabinet Secretariat'". The response of the Department of Higher Education under the Ministry of HRD was a masterpiece of obfuscation. It said the expenditure "information is compiled after complete information from the Embassy concerned is received in the Ministry, which takes considerable time". However, the ministry has provided the expenditure details for only three visits out of the nine made by the cabinet minister.

Finally, INDIA TODAY approached the Cabinet Secretariat for details of ministerial expenses, only to reach a dead-end. The

reply said, "Cabinet Secretariat is in no way the public authority concerned with the information relating to expenditure incurred on the salaries and allowances of ministers of Union Cabinet and the bills are settled between the ministries concerned and the Pay & Account Officer, Cabinet Affairs, and the CABSEC has no role in this regard." Significantly, ministries like railways, labour, tourism, external affairs, civil aviation, agriculture, urban development, finance and water resources parted with full and detailed information as requested. In cases where responses are still awaited, like the ministries of defence and textiles, information provided by PMO has been used.

Opaque procedures have daunted efforts to get a complete lowdown on the expenses. In a sense, the magnitude of the bill for official tourism is yet a bit of a mystery.



Akhilesh Das

Minister of state for steel

Number of trips: 2

Km travelled: 31,266

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Not borne by ministry

Lalu Prasad

Minister for railways

Number of trips: 1

Km travelled: 15,826

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 40 lakh

Chandra Sekhar Sahu

MoS for rural development

Number of trips: 1

Km travelled: 12,712

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 1.18 crore*

** As per official allotment*

P. Chidambaram

Minister for finance

Days as minister: 1,287

NUMBER OF TRIPS: 24

Official: 24

Personal: Nil

DAYS ABROAD: 118

Official: 118

Personal: Nil

Km travelled: 3,60,860

Official: 3,60,860 km

Personal: Nil

OFFICIAL EXPENSES:

Rs 1.45 crore

With six trips, the US tops Chidambaram's list of destinations, obviously for the IMF and World Bank meets.

